



USA: Midwest

THE AMERICAN MIDWEST is dominated by the Great Plains, once the home of cattle ranches, cowboys, and American Indian peoples. However, the discovery of gold in South Dakota brought a rush of settlers to the area. This, combined with a decline in buffalo numbers, led to the eventual displacement of the American Indians from the Plains. The area is prone to dramatic weather—tornadoes, freezing blizzards, and blazing hot summers. To the west, vast areas of farmland generate more wheat and corn than anywhere else in the world. East of the Mississippi the landscape varies and, although farming is still important, it is an industrial heartland. The greater Detroit area and other parts of Michigan make up a big manufacturing center, with other hubs in Ohio, Indiana, and Illinois.

BUFFALO ON THE PLAINS

Up to 100 million buffalo once grazed on the Great Plains. They provided local American Indians with food for the family, and skin for clothes and tepees. The Dakota people used buffalo bones to make shields and tools, and the animal's bladder into a bag for carrying water. But over-hunting and the destruction of the buffalo's habitat by early European settlers drastically reduced the number of animals. The buffalo is now a protected species and lives in reserves.

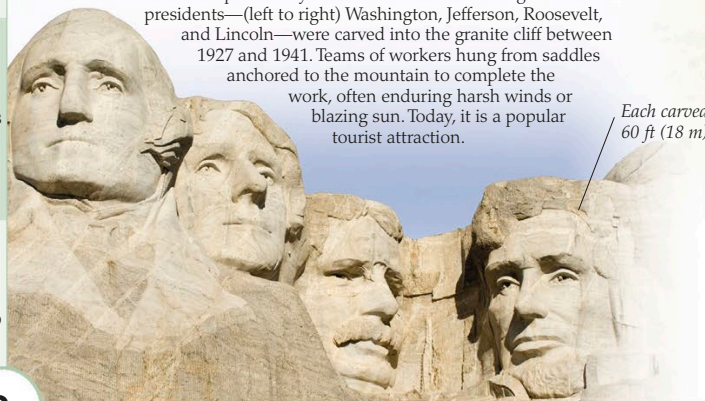


Buffalo herd on a reserve, South Dakota

MOUNT RUSHMORE NATIONAL MEMORIAL

Mount Rushmore, in the Black Hills of South Dakota, was created as a tribute to the American presidency. Four of the United States' greatest presidents—(left to right) Washington, Jefferson, Roosevelt, and Lincoln—were carved into the granite cliff between 1927 and 1941. Teams of workers hung from saddles anchored to the mountain to complete the work, often enduring harsh winds or blazing sun. Today, it is a popular tourist attraction.

Each carved face is about 60 ft (18 m) high.



TORNADO ALLEY

Dramatic tornadoes, or "twisters," regularly tear through the states of Kansas and Oklahoma along a path known as Tornado Alley. Tornadoes occur when warm and cold air masses meet. As the warm air rises it cools, and under the right conditions it can suck in more and more air until a whirling twister develops. The more air that is drawn in, the greater the power of the tornado.

